But Also Bring Cheese

By Kate Tellers

KATE: **(Pg 237-243)** In our little house [in] Pittsburgh, we had one television. We kept it behind the couch, and I was never allowed to watch it. Most nights it was my mother, my father, me . . . maybe some wooden blocks. It was very Little House on the Prairie, but in the 1980s.

One day, though, I snuck across the street to my neighbor's house, and she let me watch The Love Boat. It blew my mind. I can just picture Gavin MacLeod dressed in a captain's uniform, making out with all of these beautiful women with perfect perms. I loved it.

When I came home, I asked my mother why they kissed in that crazy way. She was like, "Well, um, when people love each other, like, a whole lot, that is the way that they kiss."

So when she came in that night to put me to bed, I grabbed her head and I smashed it up against mine, and I moved my head back, and I said, 'I'm giving you Love Boat kisses." I was obsessed with my parents.

INTRODUCTION

Memories are precious. When you lose someone, the last thing you want is to lose memories of them too. See, we spend so much time talking about things that don't matter and so little time talking about things that really do. Death is inevitable and touches each of us but talking about it is complete taboo. This has to stop. Keep your loved ones alive in your conversations, your memories. Grief may numb your body and break your heart, but grief is also just another form of love. We grieve because we love . . . and that's okay.

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KATE: When our friends were getting pets, they would get a guinea pig and name it Punky Brewster. I got two goldfish, and I named them Paul and Lisa, after my parents, because they were my rock stars.

The rest of the world existed outside of our family, so much so that when my parents divorced, I didn't get angry. I was like, Oh, this is the next thing we're doing together. I wrote my college essay on how my parents' divorce made them my two best friends and

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took us on to our next adventure together. (I did get into college, though, despite that.)

The day before I was leaving for college, my mother and I were having lunch. She confessed to me that she had seen a doctor, and she was sick. And it wasn't a big deal, she was just going to have some chemo, and she would be fine.

And I really did, honestly, believe her. But I couldn't unhear that. And I felt like I suddenly had to start considering a world with this big hole where my mom should be.

We'd be spending time together, and it's like my brain would split. And part of me would be completely present, and the other half of me would be taking all of these notes, so I could sear all of these specifics about her into my brain in case I ever needed them when she wasn't there.

After college I moved to New York. Sometimes on Friday afternoons, I would drive to Pittsburgh and I'd get in really late. [My mom would] open the door, and she'd say, "Would you like a glass of wine?" I would say, "Yes." And we both knew that it wasn't [just] a glass of wine, because it never was. She laid out all these mismatched blue-and-white plates, with white cheeses.

One night we're sitting and we're talking, and she confessed to me that the hardest thing she ever had to do as a mother was to give me ipecac to induce vomiting, because when I was little, I accidentally ate a bunch of her asthma medicine. They were these little, red-coated pills, and she could see the red in my mouth.

And I confessed to her that actually I'd eaten Red Hots. It was the only candy in our house, ever. But I knew her reaction to me eating her asthma medicine would be better than her reaction to me eating refined sugar, so I let her just go with it.

So she's laughing about this, and she throws her head back. And my brain splits. And I start to take notes. I note the way that she laughs so big that I can see the fillings in the back of her mouth. And that her head is so small that she shops in the children's section at LensCrafters. I can tell because the candlelight catches the arm of her glasses, and they say

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"Harry Potter." This is my mom. She is the most elegant and gracious woman in the world. I pick up my glass, and I toast my mother, and I look -- and she's glowing. I take her in. And I think, This is good.

Four Januaries later I'm back in Pittsburgh. The doctors have told us that it's time to come home. I'm in my mother's bathroom. She's leaning on the sink. I see her look up and look at herself in the mirror. I see a change come over her face, and I can tell that she's made up her mind. She tells me to call a nurse.

I know that this is the day that I have been afraid of for ten years. And now we're calling everyone, and we're telling them, "Come over now, for what will probably be one of the worst nights of your life."

But because I'm my mother's daughter, I'm doing this as I'm pulling her plates off of the shelf and saying, "But also bring cheese."

And they do. I've put food out, and I'm filling people's glasses of wine. People start to go in to visit my mother. I hear her saying to them, as she's laid out in her bed, "Can I get you anything? Can I get you a cup of tea?" And I'm like, "You're dying. I am going to do this right now." So I start handing people saucers and empty cups. I'm like, "Just carry this in so she knows that we're okay out here."

When the hospice first came to visit us, they gave me this pamphlet, a little blue booklet called Gone From My Sight. There's a line drawing of a ship on it. And it explains in somewhat poetic but also somewhat technical terms what happens to a body when a human being is starting to die. And I remember when they gave it to me, I was sort of furious. I thought, “There's no line drawing that can describe this very personal and very massive event in my life. This is my mom.” But on this night, it's the only guide that we have. We've never done this before.

I go in to check on her, and she's standing at her closet, and she says, "I have to pack." And I don't know what to say to that. So finally, I say, "Mommy, where you're going, you don't

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need a suitcase."

And she lays back into her bed, and she goes silent. People continue to go in, and they start to say their good-byes. Finally, it's my turn. I go into her room, and I sit down on her bed.

I know that I should say I love her, and that I'll miss her. And that in twenty-eight years I can throw her the best eighty fifth-birthday party. Then, after that, maybe sometime we'll explode in one big fireball, so that neither of us would ever have to experience what it'd be like for one of us to have to live without the other . . . But she knows all of that. So I just tell her that the following November I'm going to be a bridesmaid in my friend Jess's wedding . . . so that she knows that I have plans.

And then that's it. My mother is gone.

We all gather in the living room, and we drink all of the wine, and we eat all of the cheese. Everyone leaves, and I go to bed.

The next morning I wake up. And it's the day that I've been afraid of. I go into the kitchen, and I open up the front of the coffee machine, and I realize that I still know how to make a pot of coffee. I go into the living room, and I sit in her big blue leather chair. I open my computer, and I check my e-mail. There's an e-mail from my friend Nick and he's asking me how I am.

I hit reply, and I type, "Nick, my mom died." And it's real. I wait for that big gut punch to hit me, for that big hole to open up. That emptiness. But instead, I feel the strangest thing, the purest thing I've ever felt. I just feel sad . . .

And it feels white. And it feels hot. And it envelops me. And I feel full.

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